I'll Be Looking for You, Ace

By Jennifer Lohrfink

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Dear Michael,

So, Ace, what's it like up in heaven? Everything it's cracked up to be? People say it's supposed to be beautiful; but really, how would anyone know? Maybe that's why I used to be so afraid of dying-because we do not know what is next. Oddly enough, my feelings have changed since you left.

INTRODUCTION

One of the great losses in life is the death of a brother or sister, yet this is one of the most neglected types of grief. Everyone wonders how the parents can cope with the loss of a child, but nobody knows how hard it is for the rest of the family too. Nobody tells you what to do when your little brother dies. I'll be Looking for You, Ace by Jennifer Lohrfink

I was at work that Saturday, December 6, with only an hour to go until I had to pick you up at Vinny's house.

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Then the phone rang. It was our sister, Lauren. I was expecting to hear the usual "Remember to bring home some shampoo." Instead, there were words that reverberated through my head: "Mike's been hit by a car."

I went numb, and I shook during the entire drive to St. John's Hospital. I remember praying that your face would not be disfigured and that you did not break too many bones. Death was not even a possibility. I figured you were too good a kid, too strong, too young (you were only 11) and too well-liked to be seriously hurt.

My worst nightmare could not compare with what I found facing me. I was ushered into the doctor's lounge, where our whole family and your friends were huddled. Phrases such as "Holding his own," "It could go either way" and "There's always hope with kids" floated past my ears. I sank onto a couch. While you were in surgery, I prayed the hardest I ever prayed in my life. Then, a few hours later, the doctors let Lauren, Jeff and me up to see you in the intensive care unit.

There you were. Underneath the casts, bandages,

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bruises, stitches and tubes was the beautiful little brother I loved. The doctors said that even though you were in a coma, you might be able to hear, but I couldn't speak. Nothing I felt could be put into words. I wanted to give you the world, but I could only hold your hand. I kept thinking, ***Come on, Mike. You can make it.***

At about 10:30 that night Lauren, Jeff and I went home while Mom and Dad stayed. We played some of your albums so loud the floor shook-you would have been so proud of us!

*[Insert lyrics from KISS Song here: suggestion – "I wanna rock and roll all night . . . and party every day." *Hear the song here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=B_oFiNdp8UQ]*

After a while, I tried to fall asleep on the couch, but my mind raced. I kept thinking of how you and I danced the whole day together at cousin Becky's wedding, how you'd jump around· in your room playing air guitar, and how you messed up your lines at the Christmas play tryouts so that Brian could get the part he wanted so badly. I thought how great life was with you; without you it would be unbearable. I was so scared.

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We all did what we could for you. As an offering, Uncle Bob gave up smoking-and you know what a chain smoker he is! Your best friend, Matthew, went to church and lit 21 candles (your basketball number) for you. Lauren, Jeff and I were planning a party for you when you came home. Mom and Dad were going to get Ace Frehely [lead guitarist from KISS] to visit you.

All the hoping and planning and praying got us through that first night. In the morning, you were transferred to Columbia-Presbyterian Hospital, where it was thought that your chances for survival were greater. In Babies I.C.U. (don't get offended, Mike-Babies I.C.U. goes up to age 19!) a team of wonderful doctors and nurses stayed with you around the clock. I was there for you too, coaching you in my mind, as I used to cheer you on at your Little League games last spring. ***Come on, Mike-give it your best shot. This is not a game. This is for real.***

Well, Ace, you made it through one more night. When we got to the hospital early Monday morning, you

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were having a CAT scan done. We were told we could see you afterward. You came back in cardiac arrest, with the doctors giving one last scramble for your life.

My mind was frantic. ***You cannot die, Mike! You have too much to live for! What about the guitar lessons you were going to take-the band you were going to start with Matt and Vinny? What about the basketball team-you're the starting center. Wait, Mike, don't go. I love you too much to lose you. Keep fighting, please!***

Well, Ace, I know you did what you could. You could only fight so long with so much against you.

It was the worst moment in my life when I heard "He's gone." The room spun. I felt detached from my body, as if the pain of this startling reality was too much to bear. I wanted to die too, to be with you, to make sure you were okay.

After they took out all the tubes and monitors, the doctors let me in to see you once more. I felt that your soul was close. I wanted to shake your shoulders and have you open your eyes. Instead, I gave you a kiss and

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rested my face against yours, willing to do anything to bring you back. The only thing I could do was let you go.

Mike, I know you're still with me. I know you're helping me get on with my life. I learned so much from you. You taught me to live one day at a time, to appreciate everything that comes along, to laugh and have fun, to be honest, to accept people for what they are. And while 11 years is a short time, we filled them with so much happiness that can never be lost, even now.

The one thing you really did for me was take away my fear of death. I am no longer afraid. I know that God must have something wonderful waiting for a kid like you. My faith has also been strengthened, because if I did not believe in God and heaven, where would you be? Heaven has got to be beautiful with you there. I know that when my time comes, I will be looking for you. Could you be watching so we find each other? I really miss you, Ace, but I know that you are still with me, and I know we will see each other again.

I love you. . .

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jennifer Lohrfink
Book: Chicken Soup for the Teenage Soul
ISBN: 978-1558744639
Publisher: HCI Teens
Date (Month/Year): May 1997

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